Rising Success, Unresolved Gaps

Student-level statistics outcomes across California's placement-reform era, 2018 to 2025

Safaa Dabagh

learnwithoutwalls.com learnwithoutwalls26@gmail.com

Under review, *Journal of Postsecondary Student Success*

The policy question

California's AB 705 (2017) and AB 1705 (2022) sharply limited remedial math prerequisites. Most community college students now go straight into transfer-level courses such as statistics. Critics predicted that success would fall.

Statewide studies mix many courses, colleges and instructors. I asked two plain questions of one course:

1. With direct placement, did a larger or a smaller share of students pass?
2. Under AB 1705, did success change for each racial and ethnic group, and did the gaps get smaller?

Student-level records show what happened inside one course, group by group.

Two views of what should happen

Preparation view

Prerequisites made sure students arrived ready. Remove them and success falls.

Narrowing

Opening the gate helps Latinx and Black students most, so their gaps shrink.

Gatekeeping view

Tests filtered out students who could pass. Remove the gate and more get in, without lower success.

Rising tide

One rule for everyone lifts every group alike, and the gaps stay where they were.

In this study, equity means a gap to White students that narrows or reaches zero.

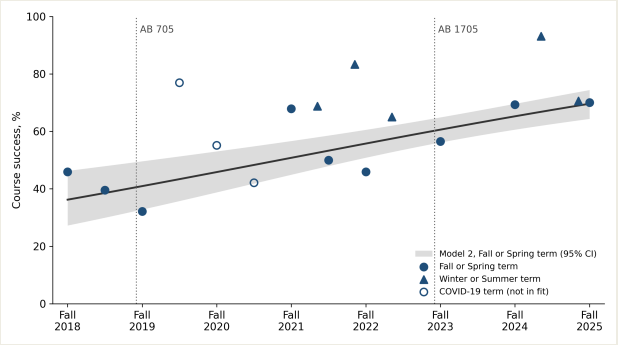
A group can improve while its gap stays the same.

The data and the design

- Official records from the college's Office of Institutional Research for every transfer-level statistics section I taught.
- 867 enrollments, 852 distinct students, 17 terms, Fall 2018 to Fall 2025.
- Success is the college's own flag: a grade of A, B, C, or P. A withdrawal counts as not passing.
- Question 1: the share passing in each period, and the yearly trend, accounting for regular versus Winter and Summer terms. The COVID-19 terms are left out of the main trend and checked with them in.
- Question 2: each group before AB 1705 (Fall 2018 to Winter 2023) and under AB 1705 (Fall 2023 to Fall 2025).

A practitioner case study: it describes what happened, not what caused it.

A larger share passed, not a smaller one



42%
before AB 705

65%
under AB 1705

Share of students who passed, Fall and Spring terms. About 23 more students out of every 100 passed.

Counting Winter and Summer terms, 69% passed under AB 1705.

No sustained decline of the kind critics predicted appeared.

Fewer students withdrew, and more who stayed passed

18.8% to 2.5%

withdrew

52% to 71%

passed, among students who stayed

Before AB 705, then under AB 1705, all terms.

The records cannot say why withdrawals fell. Deadlines, how students used them, or my own practice could all play a part.

The release contains no excused withdrawal grades. If excused withdrawals were left out of it, part of the fall in withdrawals, and so part of the rise in success, would reflect how withdrawals were recorded, not what students did.

The records cannot settle this, so I report it plainly.

The rise was steady, and it held up

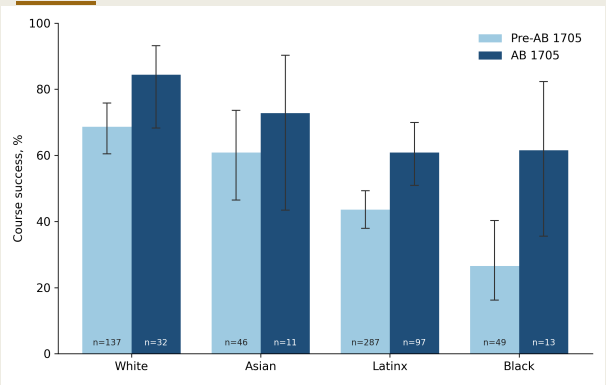
Period	Passed
Before AB 705	42.4%
AB 705 and COVID-19	49.4%
After AB 705	59.0%
AB 1705	69.0%

All terms in each period.

- Odds of passing about 22% higher each year (odds ratio 1.22, 95% CI 1.13 to 1.32).
- Predicted pass rate in a regular term: 36% in Fall 2018, 70% in Fall 2025.
- With the COVID-19 terms in: 1.17 per year. With race added: 1.27.
- Fall 2019, the first AB 705 term, was the lowest (32.1% of 84 passed), but not clearly below the rate before AB 705.

A steady climb that held in every check, not a jump when a law took effect.

Success rose in every group



Before AB 1705 and under AB 1705:

- Latinx: 44% to 61%, about 17 points (95% CI 5.8 to 28.0).
- Black: 27% to 62%, but only 13 students under AB 1705.
- White: 69% to 84%. Asian: 61% to 73%. Neither clearly different from no change.

Latinx and Black students' success clearly improved.

The White and Latinx gap barely moved

25.1 points
gap before AB 1705

23.6 points
gap under AB 1705

- White students' success rose too, so the gap stayed near 24 points in every period from Fall 2019 on.
- The change, −1.5 points (95% CI −20.1 to 17.1), fits a gap that stayed put and also a large narrowing.
- With these group sizes, only a narrowing of about 27 points or more could have been reliably detected. That is larger than the whole gap.

Whether the gap narrowed, these data cannot tell.

Missing race data

Race is missing for whole terms: Summer 2022, Summer 2025, and Fall 2025.

- Under AB 1705, race is missing for 104 of 277 enrollments (38%). Those students passed at 70.2%.
- If Latinx students in those terms had passed 30 points more often than White students, the missing records would hide a narrowing of about 22 points.
- For the gap to close completely, Latinx students in those terms would have had to pass about 39 points more often than White students. In no term with race recorded did they pass more than about 6 points more often.

Recording race for every term is a low-cost first step.

What this study cannot show

- **One instructor, one college.** I taught every section and assigned the grades. My teaching, assessment and grading may have changed over the same years.
- **Correlational.** I describe the rise without attributing it to the reforms.
- **Success among students who enrolled,** not the share of entering students who completed. No measure of prior preparation.
- **Small groups under AB 1705:** Black ($n = 13$), Asian ($n = 11$), White ($n = 32$).
- **Timing.** Below-transfer courses stayed an option until Summer 2022, and pandemic grading rules cannot be reconstructed.

These are associations from one instructor's sections, not proof that the reforms caused the change.

What this means for policy

- **The decline critics feared did not appear.** These data offer no support for restoring remedial prerequisites in statistics on the grounds that direct placement lowers success.
- **Access is not equity.** Equity needs its own goals, set and tracked apart from overall success.
- **Track results by group, with complete records,** and review them every term.
- **Support inside the course is worth testing.** 222 of the 385 students who took the corequisite support course passed statistics. These data cannot show whether support raised success.
- **The next study** should pool many instructors across several colleges, with placement data and groups large enough to detect a narrowing of a few points.

The takeaway

Opening the gate to transfer-level statistics did not lower the share of students who passed. A larger share passed: 42% before AB 705, 65% under AB 1705.

Whether it closed the gap, one course cannot tell, and the gap did not visibly close: 25 points, then 24.

Colleges that want equity need equity goals of their own, complete records to track them, and results reviewed by group every term.

Thank you.

Safaa Dabagh learnwithoutwalls.com learnwithoutwalls26@gmail.com